

Sports a part of varied life for Andy

By JACK H. SMITH

When I retired in El Paso a couple of years ago, I was interested to see the name Andy Cohen on the sports page as coach of the local university baseball nine, the Miners.

Could this possibly be the same Andy Cohen who was one of my boyhood heroes as second baseman for the Minneapolis Millers of the American Association (long before the major-league Twins)—a team that won the city's first pennant in years and met the Newark Bears in the Little World Series?

Could this be the same Andy Cohen whose community involvement and winning personality made him a civic hero as well?

Those were the days of the stock theatrical companies in the outlying cities, and the Bainbridge Players of the Minneapolis Shubert set box-office records when they signed Andy Cohen to play the Joe E. Brown role in the baseball comedy, "Elmer the Great."

Well, it was—and is—the same Andy Cohen, and last fall I met him for the first time at a meeting of the Touch-down Club, where he is a regular and is frequently called upon to deliver one of his witty-but-reverent invocations.

Although Andy played three seasons with the old New York Giants in the Polo Grounds, you're more likely to remember him if you lived close to a minor-league team. In addition to his nine years in Minneapolis, Andy played or coached at Dayton; Denver; New Orleans; Indianapolis; Elmira, N.Y.; Pine Bluff, Ark.; Eau Claire, Wis.; Waco and El Paso, where he grew up and was a three-letter man in high school.

As for the majors, Andy was a coach for the Boston Braves (pre-Atlanta) and is still known as "the winningest manager in Philadelphia history." When Eddie Sawyer resigned as manager of the Phillies just before opening-day ceremonies in 1960, Andy was rushed into the breach for just 24 hours. The Phillies won that opener.

At age 74, Andy has just "un-retired" for the second time—at least for the rest of this season—to be first-base coach for the El Paso Diablos of the Texas League. He had entered his "second career" at age 56, joining the athletic staff at the University of Texas at El Paso and building a baseball program to help the school qualify for membership in the Western Athletic Conference. He retired from college baseball managing at end of the 1978 season.

As one of the happiest and more active seniors I have met (two qualities that always seem to go together), Andy is the antithesis of the "broken-down ballplayer" so prevalent in sports lore—at least in the lore of his generation. "Today's player has an intelligent awareness that his money, arm or swing won't produce forever, plus a pension system to protect him economically," Andy says, "but, in my day, too many fellows lived up their incomes and made no future plans."

It's obvious from the pictures and clippings on the wall of Andy's trophy room that he wisely developed contacts—and satisfactions—outside the ball park everywhere he went. He has used his sports expertise and background to help others.

While inactive in baseball this past spring, Andy attended high school baseball games and scouted for outstanding players who might not yet have a college scholarship so that he could put his personal network of contacts to work for them. He's active in the Downtown Lions Club, a leading force in sports development in El Paso, and has rallied sports enterprises behind the city's volunteer beautification efforts. It's no doubt his community recognition as much as his baseball attainments that caused Andy Cohen to be the very first name voted into the city's own Sports Hall of Fame.

A good family life is a key to a happy, active senior life, too, says Andy. His wife, Barbara, "who may be the only Van Duzer ever to change her name to Cohen," is Andy's "good-health secret," he admits. He credits her with his good eating habits and proper work-rest regimen. His children all live nearby and are a comfort to him. One daughter, Kathi Jensen, manages the retail liquor establishment he owns; another daughter, Marina Nickerson, is an advertising account executive who also writes theater reviews for The El Paso Times; and his son, Henry, a recent university graduate, is in Dallas, launching a drama career.

"An older person should never think of himself as useless," Andy says. "I get up every morning, look at the sunrise, and am thankful for another day and the opportunities it will bring to use what I know, what I can do, and what I have experienced." The formula seems to work.



Andy Cohen